

Regular Meeting
April 11, 2016
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:00 p.m. Those present were Ms.Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the minutes of March 28, 2016 be approved:
Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:
Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Payrolls be approved:
Voted: That the Payrolls be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Community Participation

Cheryl Rodriguez, representing the Roberts Elementary School, stated that the school has received a grant from the Massachusetts Cultural Association to create a mosaic outside the second floor bathroom. The grant will fund the artist for the mural but not the supplies so therefore money is needed for the project.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot mentioned that money has been set aside for art projects and said this project would be a perfect candidate. Superintendent Belson said that upon School Committee approval that they will ask for funding. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if there is a theme? Ms. Rodriguez explained that it will be the many cultures of the Roberts School. Forty-one countries will be depicted into one mural. Ms. Cugno said that she would like this to be removable so it will not damage the wall or the art work. Ms. Kreatz suggested seeking outside help with the supplies perhaps from Blick or maybe setting up donation requests. Ms. Kreatz also suggested checking to see if any materials are left from the Andrews School's mural. Ms. Rodriguez thanked her for the suggestions but said that the mural will be using tiles not paints. Ms. Van der Kloot asked for the time frame? Ms.

Rodriguez answered that brainstorming has begun and the goal of the project is to unveil it on May 26th.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry to approve the request for art supplies not to exceed \$800:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Mayor Burke gave permission for a member of the audience to speak.

Angela Moore directed her question to Superintendent Belson. Ms. Moore asked if Superintendent Belson plans on retiring or will he be seeking an extension of his contract. Superintendent Belson answered that there is no decision at this time.

Ms. Moore continued by stating that a search committee should be convened before the end of the 2016 school year. She also said that if he is not planning on retiring then parents have many issues and concerns. She asked for a plan to be in place by June 2016.

Superintendent Belson reported that today at approximately 7:45 a.m. we received an automated telephone call stating that “there is a bomb in your building”. The message ran on a loop with music in the background with no reference to time, place or specific school. A sweep of the building was made and building was put into “Stay in Place” mode. Dr. Perella added that the call was very vague.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked the time frame. Dr. Perella said from the time of the call to the completion of the sweep was approximately 50 minutes. Ms. DiBenedetto said that she appreciated the quickness of the notification. Ms. Van der Kloot asked if any students were concerned or scared and if any parents were called. Dr. Perella said that a few parents called seeking clarification but they were happy that the students were safe and secure. No students needed counseling. Ms. Kreatz said that she spoke to a few parents and students and that everything remained calm. Ms. DiBenedetto asked Dr. Perella to send a follow-up within 24 hours if any new information or details are received.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot the request was approved:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Presentation by Medford Public Library Youth Services Librarian

Youth Services Librarian Samantha Sednek said that it is the goal of the Medford Public Library to form a partnership with the Medford Public Schools. The purpose of this partnership is to get every child in Medford a library card. This partnership is a good way to promote literacy and resourcefulness for our students and their families. Ms. Sednek gave a Power Point presentation of the additional resources that the library offers without any cost. She suggested adding a library card to the supply list for the next school year.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno asked if the library could just visit each classroom and issue cards to the students. Ms. Sednek answered that they need parent's permission. Ms. DiBenedetto suggested putting the application for a library card in the student registration packet. Ms. DiBenedetto would like to find a way to develop a districtwide plan to get every student a library card. Superintendent Belson said that he is sure there is a way to make this happen. It is a great idea. Ms. DiBenedetto suggested setting up a program in the school and having someone in district oversee it so that it is ready for next school year. Mr. Skerry suggested having the public relations officer reach out to the parents and local press to have a campaign in May. Ms. Van der Kloot asked how many classes visit the library? Ms. Sednek said that an email is sent to all principals inviting their teachers and students to visit. Approximately $\frac{3}{4}$ of kindergarten and $\frac{1}{2}$ of first grades visit. Ms. Van der Kloot suggested making this a field trip for all kindergarten students. Ms. Cugno said that she doesn't want to bombard Ms. Sednek and asked if she has the manpower to handle this. She replied that she is confident that they can handle this.

On the motion that the application for a library card be part of the student registration packet:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve Record Board for the Pool

The Feeley Family has generously donated a record board for the new pool area. Mary Judge reported that the Feeley Family approached her asking what was needed for the area. They graciously donated the record board. The donation would include the board, shipping and handling, and installation. The approximate cost is \$3500.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto requested that a letter of thanks be sent. Mr. Skerry thanked the Feeley Family for everything they have done over the years.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the donation of the record board from the Feeley Family:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve Student Trip to Italy April 2017

Director of Foreign Language Rita DiCarlo stated that she is requesting approval for a trip to Italy which will coincide with April vacation 2017. Nicole Chalifoux will serve as trip leader. Travel Design an educational travel agency will organize the trip.

Discussion:

Mayor Burke asked if a cancellation policy is included. Ms. DiCarlo answered that all students will be made to purchase cancellation insurance. Mr. Skerry asked if there is any provision if a student can't pay the entire price. Ms. DiCarlo said no, that in the past they

have tried fundraisers but they did not work out well. Ms. Van der Kloot asked what the total price is? Ms. DiCarlo said approximately \$4000. Ms. Van der Kloot said last trip was to Italy/France, any reason this trip is only to Italy. Ms. DiCarlo said that last time they combined with the French classes. Ms. Cugno asked how many students will be going? Ms. DiCarlo answered that they recently had a meeting and there are about 40-44 students interested. Ms. Cugno asked for the breakdown of students to chaperones. Ms. DiCarlo responded that there are 6 students to every chaperone. Ms. DiBenedetto requested that Ms. DiCarlo explain to the parents that the cancellation insurance doesn't reimburse them 100%.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to approve the trip to Italy, April 2017:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Report on Regional Science and Engineering Fair

Coordinator of Science Rocco Cieri presented the report. Mr. Cieri reported that Medford High School students participated in the Region IV Science and Engineering Fair on March 12th. This year's fair had over 100 projects. Medford High School student Ann Le took home one of the top three prizes. Her project entitled the "Viability of co-cultured Mycobacterium smegmatic and THP-1 cell-derived macrophages following infections in vitro" was awarded second place and has qualified for both the state science and engineering fair and the Intel International Science and Engineering Fair in Arizona. Ann Le was congratulated by the School Committee and presented with an award certificate.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked where she did her lab work? Ms. Le answered at Tufts University. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if the new science labs have helped her. Ms. Le said that as a freshman she was not able to do many experiments but now they are so sophisticated and helpful they can do anything. Ms. Van der Kloot asked if she was awarded money to help pay for the trip. Ms. Le answered that it is paid for my Intel. Ms. Van der Kloot would like letters of congratulations sent to all 43 students that participated. Mr. Cieri informed everyone that on May 24th President Monaco from Tufts University will be visiting the science department.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to send congratulatory letter to the students:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Update on Gender Identity Non-Discrimination Policy

Superintendent Belson presented the update. He reported that In 2013 the Medford School Committee approved a Gender Identity Non-Discrimination Policy. This past month the MASC, MASS, MTA, AFT joined together to support pending legislation (see attached) to provide explicit protection from discrimination in public places for transgender men, women, and children in Massachusetts. While state law already protects

transgender students in public schools, we must be advocates for our students and staff when they leave school and visit a hospital, public park, local mall, or restaurant. Our current policy is a good one but it must be reinforced to achieve the objective of non-discrimination for all our students.

The Medford High School site council has established as one of its objectives that we assess our high school student body to determine an accurate gender identity demographic. This will serve two purposes:

1. to accurately report demographics to the state on mandated reports
2. to obtain the necessary data to properly structure student support based upon gender diversity

Therefore the site council will conduct a voluntary and anonymous online survey of high school students on gender identity. The individual results will be totally confidential. This report is provided to you to keep you informed of our proactive approach to meeting the needs of all our students.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Recommendation to Re-Affirm Medford Public Schools Drug and Alcohol Policy
Superintendent Belson stated that the recent passage of H4056 entitled “An Act Relative to Substance Use, Treatment, Education and Prevention requires that we update our drug and alcohol policy. While we await definitive guidance from the state we should proactively add, delete, substitute, and modify certain sections to reflect the obvious changes and to have an online policy in place consistent with the emergency preamble to the Act. When we receive formal guidance from the state we will return to this policy and make it consistent with their directions. The policy for the high school has additional provisions reflecting that age groups and level of seriousness. The attached changes primarily address that policy but are applicable to all grade levels. We also have to factor in the requirements of Chapter 222 on student discipline.

Please note the recommended interim changes:

- Page 36 – Eliminate CASPAR (alcohol and drug education)
- Page 36 – under prevention 2nd paragraph
Subject to appropriation the Medford Public Schools will utilize a verbal screening tool to screen pupils for substance abuse disorders. Screenings shall occur on an annual basis and occur at two different grade levels as recommended by the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education in consultation with the department of Mental Health. Parents or guardians of a pupil to be screened pursuant to the law and this policy will be notified prior to the start of the school year. If a student arrives in the school district after the start of the school year he/she will be screened within sixty days of arrival.
Pupils or pupils guardians may opt out of the screening by written notification at any time prior to the screening.
- Page 37 – Substitute Assistant Principal for Submaster
Add Principal to term Headmaster

- Page 37 – A student in violation may be suspended up to three days depending on the violation. Social probation may be imposed
- Page 38 – Third Offense
A student in violation may be suspended up to 10 days. Principals must provide alternative education consistent with Chapter 222. An exclusionary action by the school can only occur consistent with the laws governing that option.
- Social Probation
Substitute “may not” for “will not” be allowed to attend or participate in graduation.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked if there is something in the policy that teachers, coaches and staff have to read and sign or appropriate action will be taken. Also she wants parents to sign. Ms. Mustone said that there is one bullet that she would like explained about Social Probation. She said that these are children and they make mistakes. Superintendent Belson said that the change is from will not to may not. Ms. Van der Kloot explained about a very hard time when a sweet young lady was not able to attend graduation. She remembers that it was one of the hardest things she has ever had to make a decision on. She asked Dr. Perella to remind students that this is an important time in their life. Ms. Kreatz mentioned this is prom season and a good time to talk to juniors and seniors about consequences. Ms. Cugno also said that it is very difficult when a student can't graduate. It broke her heart but she wants everyone to be treated equally if we are changing the policy. Ms. DiBenedetto explained about the Up All Night Party after the junior prom. She would like to recognize Ann Repucci with a plaque to honor her for all her years of service. Ms. Van der Kloot added that she would like a reserved seat on stage for Ms. Reppucci.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedettoto accept the policy revision including all teachers, coaches and staff must read and sign the policy

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Financial Report

Director of Finance and Administration Pat Velie presented the report. Ms. Velie reported that the budget is on target for this time of the year. Ms. Velie highlighted the many tasks being done by the business office. She stated that the food service department closed out the adjusted end of year balance \$88,921 adjusted in that June Federal and State revenue is not reflected until the next year, as it arrives after close of year, and should be taken into end of year balance consideration. Special education's out of district tuition continues to maintain stability. Substitute teachers account line should be adequate barring any unexpected long-term needs. The high school telephone conversion will be completed April 15. Training for staff will be April 14. Bus routes are running smoothly and during the lighter than normal winter we experienced few reported issues. On Jan 19th Eastern Bus Company drivers were trained in the use of Epipens by Toni Vento. The utilities for the month of February used 48% less therms than a year ago, overall for the fiscal year 28% less has been used than the previous year. The FY16

school year has had its share of unplanned maintenance issues: failed water heater, sewer cleanup, concrete work, but careful spending has thus far managed to keep the budget aligned as planned.

Discussion:

Mr. Skerry asked if the energy office has done an audit at the high school? Ms. Velie replied that it has been done that we are waiting to see how it pans out. Ms. Van der Kloot commented that because of the mild winter we have saved monies but we need to still be mindful during budget to keep the monies in these accounts. She also said that the surplus money in the school lunch account should go to the needed items and upgrades. Ms. DiBenedetti said that in regards to conserving energy that the Curtis Tufts needs new lights. Mayor Burke said that Greenscape has selected the Curtis Tufts as one of the schools for new lights.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the report and place on file:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Italian Students win Prize

Rita DiCarlo presented the report. She stated that ten students from three different Italian classes and levels at Medford High School created an original skit in Italian and competed against other area high schools at Northeastern University on the morning of April 8, 2016 during the first annual “*Giornata dell’Italiano*” (“Italian Day”). Medford High School won first place, Lexington High School won second place and Everett High School won third place. The Student’s Choice Award went to Everett High School. This was the first time this contest was open to Massachusetts students, but it is an event that has been held for many years in New Jersey, where Everett Italian teacher, Steven LaPeruta taught for several years. Having moved to Massachusetts and now teaching at Everett High School, Mr. LaPeruta spearheaded efforts to bring the contest to Massachusetts high schools. The guidelines for students participating in the contest were to create a five-minute original skit on an Italian feast or national celebration, outlining its social characteristics and cultural tendencies. The Medford group, that was composed by two students from Italian II Honors: Lia BenDaniel and Zoe Salvato Cutter; two students from Italian IV Honors: Emiline Antunes and John Maffeo; and six students from Italian AP: Gislaine Braga, Rachel Garland, Ethan Greenidge, Jillian McCarthy and Michelle Nguyen, chose the theme of “*Carnevale*”. Their skit consisted of an imaginative fashion show/contest in which students featured stock characters from *La Commedia dell’Arte*. Through their dialog, elements and tendencies of Italian culture pertaining to the celebration of *Carnevale* came through with a humorous and modern twist. On the onset, students worked collaboratively on their own time using Google Docs to create the script and then met after school to practice their lines under the direction of MHS Italian teachers Ms. Canetta, Ms. Chalifoux, Ms. Hoffman; and Foreign Language Director/Italian AP teacher, Rita DiCarlo. MHS students walked away from the competition with pride and renewed excitement for the study of Italian. Working collaboratively with students of different levels, they demonstrated the true spirit of collaboration that MHS is built on, and showcased maturity and commitment which led them to victory! We would all like to acknowledge and thank Cesare Pietrangelo for

sponsoring the Medford group through the generous donation from the Michelina Pietrangelo Scholarship Fund.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno requested that a letter of recognition be sent to the students. Ms. DiBenedetto would like to invite the students to a School Committee meeting and present them with certificates.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report of Legal Counsel on School Rentals

Attorney Howard Greenspan reports the following:

1. The statute as interpreted by our Supreme Judicial Court allows the School Committee to charge fees for the use of school premises to profit and not for profit organizations consistent with its regulations.
2. While it is clear that the statute allows the committee to rent to for profit organizations, there are four conflicting policies online that should be resolved by the Committee that will establish clearly Medford Public Schools policy on school rentals.

Therefore, the administration is drafting a policy for School Committee consideration that will clarify the matter. Of course the committee may modify/change any part of the administration's recommendations. Superintendent Belson added that we have been working on a new policy and fee structure since our last Committee of the Whole. We would expect to have it ready for your review by the first meeting in May. Any new policy should be carefully studied and approved for the next school year. Attorney Greenspan recommended reviewing the policies that he presented and said that there was a substantial portion of the policy book that was not adopted by the committee.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked if we have dates the policy was put into place. Superintendent Belson answered that they are researching the minutes from March 2012. He said if you go online to where MASC has posted the policies the four in question are not there. Ms. Van der Kloot stated that MASC brought policies and we went over them line by line, night after night. Ms. DiBenedetto said when researching that MASC is the source. She said that the Committee of the Whole meeting on March 19th was to discuss community schools and who is renting, using theaters, how much are they paying. She requested a complete understanding and has been asking for this for months. Superintendent Belson replied that they have agreed to do that but first needed the legal opinion. We are working on a comprehensive fee structure and will provide a list of renters and booster clubs registered with schools. He also said that we are doing our homework going forward and you will have a fee structure for next school year. You are going to get a

very comprehensive report. Mayor Burke asked to consider allowing practice in cage for Medford Little League, Medford Softball and Medford Babe Ruth without fee structure.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry to move approval Ms. DiBenedetto asked for a list of people who are using facilities free of charge and who is monitoring them and doing maintenance? She wants this tabled until we know what we are doing.

On the motion to table:

Roll Call:

Yes: 1 DiBenedetto

No: 6 Cugno, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Superintendent Belson commented that if approved that we will contact individuals for the leagues regarding schedules and if it is only a small amount of time they are requesting we will absorb the cost. Ms. DiBenedetto asked for a list of community groups and if they are all non profit. She asked if the Fire Marshal has to inspect and how many can there be in that area? She also wants a list of people with keys. Mr. Skerry recommends that Mr. Greenspan's plan be sent to Buildings and Grounds and that a Buildings and Grounds sub-committee meeting be scheduled going forward.

On the motion to allow Medford Little League, Medford Softball and Medford Babe Ruth to use the area and send the paper to sub committee on buildings and grounds:

Roll Call:

Yes: 6 Cugno, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

No: 1 DiBenedetto

Jean Martin was given permission to speak. Ms. Martin said that the school buildings were built for the kids. She is against having adults from outside groups using our public school. She said that she wanted to go on record for this comment.

On the motion to move Negotiations and Legal Matter to the end of the calendar.

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Old Business

Authorization to Submit Letter to Our Legislative Delegation Recommending Rejection of a Charter Cap Lift

Superintendent Belson stated that this proposal is for more than a charter bill. It addresses many issues including the implementation of a seven-year roll out to implement the Foundation Budget Review Commission recommendation. It is very comprehensive. It requires full funding before expansion of charters. The full Senate will debate the bill starting on April 4, 2016. We know that there are differences among the involved parties but this bill brings to light many of the charter issues that we have advocated for over the years. We may want to withhold our letter or revise it to reflect this proposal. Superintendent Belson suggested drafting another letter to reflect the changes on Beacon Hill.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno said to go ahead and make the edits and send letter out asap. Superintendent Belson said that our next meeting is scheduled for May 2nd so he will bring the changes then. Ms. DiBenedetto suggested holding the letter due to the changes and parts need tweeking, if we send it now it is not good timing. Ms. Cugno said that the letter needs to be done now. Superintendent Belson said that there are some pieces in the Senate legislation we should support. Ms. Van der Kloot is concerned that the next meeting is three weeks away and that she feels that Medford should go on record for being against raising the cap on charter schools. Superintendent Belson suggested that he would draft the letter and the committee can review it at the Committee of the Whole meeting on April 25th.

On the motion of to review the draft letter on April 25th:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

New Business:

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Carol (Ferrone) Mastromauro. Carol was a graduate of Medford High School Class of 1967 and also a history teacher at Medford High School for many years.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family Marjorie Bennett. Mrs. Bennett was a lifelong Medford resident and a secretary for Medford High School for many years.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to go into Executive Session at 9:35 p.m. for the discussion of MTA grievance and update on all units collective bargaining.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Executive Session ended at 10:45 p.m. with no return by the Committee.

Respectfully submitted:

Robert E. Skerry Jr.
Secretary

